ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why Does Evil Exist If God Is One?

Derech Hashem 4:4:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraph 1 (most of it) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 31 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The longest chapter in the book

Part 4 is about our service of God: Torah study (chapter 2), and then observance in four categories. Last week we covered the constant misvot, love and fear of God. Now we come to the daily misvot: chapter 4 is Kriat Shema and its berakhot, and chapter 5 is Tefillah.

"These are the only two misvot which you have to do every day." Out of all the misvot, only these two apply every single day of the year. And chapter 4 is the longest chapter in the whole of Derech Hashem, which tells you how central Shema and Yihud Hashem, the unity of God, are in the Ramhal's thought. "We've talked about Yihud Hashem countless times in the past, but this is the source of it all."

A participant asked whether the chapter covers the Amidah. No: this chapter is entirely Shema and its berakhot, morning and night; Tefillah comes next. The heart of it is *Shema Yisrael* and *Barukh Shem*, with brief mention of the other paragraphs and the berakhot.

The point of Shema in one sentence

Two services are required of us every day: Kriat Shema and Tefillah, which corresponds to the daily and Musaf offerings of Temple times. The whole point of Shema, in one sentence, is the acknowledgement of God's oneness and the acceptance of His sovereignty as King.

Everything traces back to one source

God gave different creatures, physical and spiritual, the ability to do different things, but He is the origin and cause of all of it. This is true in two respects: **existence** and **action**.

Existence. The Rabbi returned to the analogy he gave when the series began two years earlier: close your eyes and create a beautiful universe in your mind, dwell on it, develop it. Then the phone rings, your mind turns away, and that universe is gone. So too this entire universe depends at every moment on God willing it. His existence is different: it is necessary existence, dependent on nothing, one of the six principles in Part 1, chapter 1.

This is why the Rambam calls only God *emet*. "It's true that I'm wearing a jacket today. But it doesn't have to be true." Emet means something that must be so, like one plus one equals

two. That we exist is true but not necessary; that God exists is emet.

Action. God has given creatures abilities, even free will: angels act, people act, animals act. Ants build whole systems. But they have no power of their own, only what God gives them and continues to give them, and He can increase or reduce it at any time.

The Rabbi brought the *Tomer Devorah* of the Ramak, Rabbi Moshe Cordovero of Safed in the Arizal's time, on God's attributes of mercy. If a bee stings you, your instinct is to kill it. Now imagine that you were the one giving the bee its power, and it stung you, and you continued to give it the power. That is what God does with us.

Free will, the ox, and the Holocaust

A participant asked about the ox that gores and is put to death: if it only did what its nature allowed, why should it suffer? The Rabbi cautioned against saying God "told" it to gore. The ox acted according to its nature; God could have prevented the death and did not.

He applied this to the hardest question: where was God in the Holocaust? Rabbi Sacks used to say the real question is "where was man?" It was a human calamity: people with free will chose to act barbarically. "To ask why did God do this, that's a stupid question, because God didn't do it. Human beings did it." What one can ask, and it is a really difficult question, is why God did not intervene. A participant added that if everything is for the good, there must be something in the future for which He did not intervene. Can we answer it fully? "I don't know if we can fully."

The apparent contradiction

The Ramhal then raises the difficulty. Recall from Part 1: the purpose of creation is to cleave to God by becoming good, and we acquire goodness by choosing it over bad, so bad must exist. Evil in the world comes either from human choice or from God's decree. Either way, there is bad.

"This is the crux of Yihud Hashem." Look at the world: it is dark and gloomy, the wicked rule, God's name is profaned. If a perfect God controls both existence and action, and God only wants good, how can there be evil? It looks as if there must be other powers, as if the world denies God's oneness.

The one who looks deeper

The answer: one who understands God's ways and goes deeper sees that all of this is a great series of circuits leading to the completion and perfection of creation. God allows it as part of a deep plan, and only His counsel will stand: goodness for His creatures. "And after all these circuits it will be well known that He is One, Unique and Single", and that He causes all these cycles to reach the true end, the ultimate good.

So at a superficial level it seems there is more than one force. But if we think about Yihud Hashem, we believe, even when we do not see it, that God is the One, and everything is part of the plan. That is what Shema is about, to be continued on Thursday.

Summary

- Shema and Tefillah are the only misvot obliged every day; the chapter on Shema is the longest in the book.
- Shema means acknowledging God's oneness and accepting His kingship.
- All existence and all action depend constantly on God's will; only His existence is necessary, *emet*.
- Human beings cause evil through free will; the hard question is why God does not intervene.
- Evil seems to deny God's unity, but the deeper view sees it as part of one plan leading to ultimate good.

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